the community. Nearly half of the 67 Lingayat MLAs in 1999 were Congressmen, but that was because of a split in the Janata Dal. However, the period just marked the transition to a new era where Yediyurappa was coming into his own as a Lingayat leader.

A second such split in a party—brought about by Yediyurappa himself when he separated acrimoniously from the BJP to helm his own outfit, the Karnataka Janata Party—benefitted the Congress in 2013 but not before further cementing Yediyurappa's credentials. He returned as the state BJP party president in 2016. How the Lingayats rallied behind him is fairly recent history. In 2018, ahead of the election, Congress chief minister Siddaramaiah acceded to a long-standing demand for the Lingayat faith to be recognised as a separate religion. But what his government recommended was to differentiate between the Veerashaivas and the Lingayats—on adherence to Basava tenets—when the two terms had always been used synonymously. Accused of trying to split the Veerashaiva-Lingayats, several Congress leaders faced defeat in the 2018 election. "The Congress tried to create confusion within the community and wanted to draw benefit out of it. But since Yediyurappa was at the helm of party affairs, he was able to control the damage at that time," says B.Y. Vijayendra, the younger son of Yediyurappa. "Now, they have realised their earlier mistakes."

The BJP, on its part, is careful to avoid such a mistake. Wary of the Congress cashing in on the perception that the ageing leader was being sidelined after he stepped down as CM in 2021, the BJP central leadership in August 2022 appointed Yediyurappa to two of its top panels—the BJP parliamentary board and the central election committee. "Yediyurappaji has also said on umpteen occasions that the party has given everything to him... he was party president, deputy CM, and then CM. His dream is to see BJP coming back with absolute majority and he's not going to sit back," says Vijayendra. "Even though he is not fighting elections, his role definitely will be very crucial for the BJP... Naturally, he has more responsibility than anyone else." Vijayendra, who hopes to contest from his father's constituency of Shikaripura, is a vice president of the state BJP unit. While he has not contested an assembly poll yet, he is credited with overseeing two byelection victories in KR Pet and Sira in 2019—seats the BJP had never won before. Vijayendra is currently in charge of the BJP's morcha conventions across the state. But Yediyurappa passing on the Shikaripura baton to his son is a subject the BJP—which attacks rival parties on the issue of *parivarvad*—hasn't openly broached yet. Yediyurappa's elder son B.Y. Raghavendra is a two-term MP from Shivamogga.



ANI

BIG SHOES TO FILL Basavaraj Bommai

IN 2021, WHILE REPLACING YEDIYURAPPA WITH BOMMAI AS CM, THE BJP WAS CAREFUL IN CHOOSING A FELLOW LINGAYAT

Yet, even with the BJP at the helm in Karnataka, sections of the Lingayats have been up in arms—for the past two years, the Panchamashalis have led agitations demanding higher reservations. With some BJP leaders such as Vijayapura MLA Basanagouda Patil Yatnal backing the stir, the Bommai government in December came up with a rejig of the OBC quota categories but it hasn't satisfied the agitators. "There has been no order or notification about this. Hence, we had no choice but to continue our agitation," says Basava Jaya Mruthyunjaya Swami, a Panchamashali seer who has been on a sit-in protest in Bengaluru for two months now. The seer, pointing out that the Panchamashalis account for 82 per cent of the Lingayat population, is threatening to mobilise people in north Karnataka if the government doesn't act soon.

Candidate selection will be vital in wooing the Veerashaiva-Lingayats, political observers note. In 2018, the Congress fielded 43 Lingayats, 16 of whom won, while the BJP gave tickets to 67 who won 38 seats. Spread over several regions of the state, the community has a presence in at least 154 of Karnataka's 224 seats, including some reserved for SC/ST candidates. Besides, the Lingayat religious institutions, or *mathas*, are also seen to wield significant influence in framing public opinion.

Hence, every signal from political parties comes under close Lingayat scrutiny. It was amidst this that H.D. Kumaraswamy created a ripple recently claiming there was an RSS plan to make Union minister Pralhad Joshi the CM if the BJP wins. A former CM and a leader of the Vokkaliga community—the state's other powerful caste group—Kumaraswamy was fighting back Joshi's potshots, calling out his party, the Janata Dal (Secular), for being a family-run outfit when he brought up his 'Peshwa Brahmin' roots to make the allegation; where it was aimed at was clear to all. "Projecting Yediyurappa without him being in power won't convince the Lingayats," says a community leader. A BJP leader admits, "There is the question of who after Yediyurappa. The party has to answer that." On that will hinge the BJP's fortunes in the south. ■